# First Inaugural Address

*President Abraham Lincoln · March 4, 1861*

*Source: Abraham Lincoln, First Inaugural Address (1861). Public domain. Continuous passage.*

> With seven states already seceded, Lincoln argued the Union was perpetual and could not be legally broken, pledged not to interfere with slavery where it existed, but vowed to hold federal property — closing with an appeal to "the better angels of our nature."

I hold that in contemplation of universal law and of the Constitution the Union of these States is perpetual. Perpetuity is implied, if not expressed, in the fundamental law of all national governments. . . . It follows from these views that no State upon its own mere motion can lawfully get out of the Union; that resolves and ordinances to that effect are legally void.

[ . . . ]

In your hands, my dissatisfied fellow-countrymen, and not in mine, is the momentous issue of civil war. The Government will not assail you. You can have no conflict without being yourselves the aggressors. . . . I am loath to close. We are not enemies, but friends. We must not be enemies. Though passion may have strained it must not break our bonds of affection. The mystic chords of memory . . . will yet swell the chorus of the Union, when again touched, as surely they will be, by the better angels of our nature.